Side Hustle for Firefighters in 2026: 10 Ways to Make Extra Money on Days Off

Working as a firefighter can provide a stable career, but many firefighters also look for ways to earn additional money outside their regular shifts. The good news is that a firefighter's schedule can make certain side jobs easier to manage than they are for people who work a traditional Monday-to-Friday job.

A side hustle for firefighters can range from picking up extra EMS shifts to using skills in home inspection, fire-safety consulting, handyman work, fitness coaching, or property maintenance. Some options require an existing certification, while others can be started with basic equipment and a relatively small investment.

The key is finding a side job that works with your department schedule, does not interfere with recovery time, and complies with your department's outside-employment rules.



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In this guide, we explore practical side hustles for firefighters, how they work, what skills they require, potential earning models, and how to choose an option that fits your days off.

Why Firefighters Have Good Opportunities for Side Hustles

Firefighters often work schedules that are very different from conventional employees. A 24-hour shift can be followed by multiple days away from the station. Depending on the department, firefighters may work schedules such as 24-on/48-off or 24-on/72-off.

That creates blocks of free time that can be used for appointments, project-based work, business activities, or additional shifts.

Instead of looking for a part-time job that requires someone to work two or three hours every evening, firefighters can focus on work that can be completed during an entire day.

This is particularly useful for:

- Per-diem EMS shifts
- Home inspections
- Handyman projects

- Landscaping
- Safety training
- Consulting
- Personal training
- Fire investigation work

However, having free days does not automatically mean every side hustle is a good fit.

Firefighters should consider sleep, physical recovery, family responsibilities, commute time, department policies, insurance requirements, licensing rules, and taxes before committing to additional work.

What Makes a Good Side Hustle for Firefighters?

The most useful side hustles for firefighters generally have at least one of these characteristics:

Flexible scheduling

The work should allow you to select your available days instead of requiring a fixed weekday schedule.

Existing skills

A side hustle becomes easier to start when it uses knowledge you already have. Firefighters may already have experience with emergency response, safety procedures, inspections, first aid, physical training, equipment maintenance, and risk assessment.

Reasonable startup costs

A side business does not necessarily need expensive equipment. Some opportunities can be started with an existing certification or basic tools.

Strong earning potential

The goal of a side hustle is additional income, so compare the money earned with the time, travel, equipment, insurance, and administrative work involved.

Manageable liability

Some firefighter-related work involves significant responsibility. Consulting, inspection and investigation services can carry professional liability, making appropriate insurance and credentials important.

10 Side Hustles for Firefighters in 2026

1. Per-Diem EMT or Paramedic Work

For firefighters who already have an active EMT or paramedic certification, per-diem EMS work can be one of the most straightforward ways to earn additional income.

Instead of accepting a permanent second job, you can join a per-diem roster and pick available shifts that fit your schedule.

Private ambulance companies, medical transport providers and nearby EMS organizations may offer this type of work.

The major advantage is that the job uses skills you may already use as part of your firefighting career.

How to get started

- Check that your EMT or paramedic certification is current.
- Confirm required CPR or other credentials.
- Look for per-diem openings with local EMS providers.
- Complete any required orientation or onboarding.
- Choose shifts that fit your department schedule.

A 12-hour shift can sometimes fit neatly into a day away from the fire station.

The original source identifies per-diem EMS work as one of the fastest-paying options because firefighters with the appropriate certification may not need to learn an entirely new profession.

2. Handyman and Home Repair Services

If you are comfortable working with tools, handyman services can become a flexible side hustle for firefighters.

Small property-maintenance jobs can include:

- Drywall repairs
- Furniture assembly
- Minor carpentry
- Painting
- Fixture installation
- Basic maintenance
- Yard-related repairs
- General home improvement

The advantage is that many projects can be scheduled around your days off.

For example, instead of working every evening, you could reserve one or two full days for customer projects.

Platforms that connect local service providers with customers can help beginners find their first clients, although you can also build business through referrals and local marketing.

Important consideration

Do not assume that every type of repair work is legal without a license.

Electrical, plumbing, structural and larger construction projects may have specific licensing requirements depending on your location. Check local and state rules before accepting work.

Insurance is also important because you are working on someone else's property.

The source article notes that handyman work can have significantly higher self-employed billable rates than ordinary employee wages, but business expenses reduce the amount you actually keep.

3. Fire and Life Safety Consulting

Your professional experience can potentially become a consulting business.

Fire and life safety consultants may help organizations understand safety requirements, identify hazards, prepare for inspections, or review plans.

Possible clients can include:

- Businesses
- Contractors
- Property managers
- Building owners
- Architects
- Organizations responsible for public facilities

This can be a higher-value firefighter side hustle, but it generally requires more credibility and preparation than simple gig work.

You may need specialized credentials, professional insurance and a business structure appropriate for the services you provide.

The source specifically discusses plan reviews, code-compliance walkthroughs and pre-inspection consulting as possible areas where firefighting and inspection experience can transfer.

Why it can take time

Consulting is different from picking up an EMS shift.

You may need to spend months developing relationships and finding clients. Networking with professionals in construction, architecture, property management and fire safety can therefore be more important than simply posting an online advertisement.

4. Home Inspection

Home inspection is another option that can make use of a firefighter's understanding of buildings, hazards and safety.

A home inspector examines a property and prepares a report describing observed conditions.

Typical inspection areas may include:

- Electrical systems
- Roofing
- Plumbing
- Structural components

- Heating and cooling systems
- Safety concerns
- Visible property defects

The source article points out that the building-safety knowledge developed through fire inspection can overlap with the skills used during home inspections.

Getting started as a home inspector

Before accepting customers, investigate your state's requirements. Licensing and training rules differ by location.

You may also need:

- Professional training
- Certification
- Liability insurance
- Inspection equipment
- Report-writing software
- Business registration

Building relationships with real estate professionals can also help generate referrals.

Home inspection can work particularly well with a firefighter schedule because an individual inspection generally requires a concentrated block of time rather than short daily shifts.

5. CPR, First Aid and Safety Training

Teaching CPR and first aid is another potential source of firefighter side income.

Firefighters often already have familiarity with emergency medical procedures, although becoming an instructor can require additional training or affiliation with an approved training organization.

Potential customers include:

- Daycare centers
- Schools
- Sports organizations
- Small businesses
- Community groups
- Healthcare-related organizations

Instead of charging by the hour, instructors may charge per participant or per class.

This creates an interesting model for firefighters because an entire class can be scheduled on a single day off.

How to build recurring income

One class may provide only occasional income. A better long-term approach is to develop relationships with organizations that need recurring certification.

For example, businesses may need employee training periodically, creating an opportunity for repeat bookings.

The source article describes CPR and first-aid instruction as a side job that can be paid by class rather than simply by the hour.

6. Fire Investigation and Cause-and-Origin Consulting

Experienced firefighters with the appropriate qualifications may eventually explore fire investigation consulting.

This work can involve analyzing fire scenes, reviewing evidence, preparing reports and providing professional opinions within one's qualifications.

Potential clients can include:

- Insurance companies
- Attorneys
- Property owners
- Investigative organizations

However, this should not be viewed as a quick side hustle.

It can require specialized credentials, experience, professional networking and substantial responsibility.

The source notes that cause-and-origin consulting can have a high hourly earning ceiling but may take significantly longer to establish because building a referral network takes time.

Who should consider it?

This option is generally more suitable for firefighters who already have relevant investigation experience or are willing to pursue the necessary professional qualifications.

It is better approached as a long-term professional service rather than a quick-cash opportunity.

7. Personal Training and Fitness Coaching

Firefighters already understand the importance of physical conditioning, which can make fitness coaching an interesting career-adjacent side business.

After obtaining the appropriate certification, you could work with clients who want help with:

- Strength training
- General fitness
- Conditioning
- Weight-management goals
- Exercise routines

- Functional training

Sessions can be scheduled individually, making this a flexible part-time job for firefighters.

For example, you might train one client in the morning and another in the afternoon rather than spending an entire day at another workplace.

Certification matters

Professional certification can improve credibility and may be required by gyms or insurance providers.

You should also understand the difference between providing general fitness coaching and offering medical or nutritional advice that may fall outside your qualifications.

The source article identifies personal training as an option with an upfront certification cost but a schedule that can accommodate individual sessions on days off.

8. Landscaping and Property Maintenance

Landscaping can be started relatively simply compared with some professional consulting businesses.

Basic services can include:

- Lawn mowing
- Trimming
- Yard cleanup
- Mulching
- Leaf removal
- Hedge trimming
- Seasonal property maintenance

The biggest advantage is scheduling.

Customers often need recurring service weekly or every couple of weeks, which can fit around a firefighter's rotating schedule if the route is planned carefully.

Start small

You do not need dozens of customers immediately.

A firefighter could start with a small group of nearby clients and gradually increase the route.

Keeping customers geographically close is especially useful because driving between jobs reduces the number of billable hours.

The source article highlights mowing, trimming, cleanup and recurring property work as ways a landscaping operation can expand beyond simple lawn cutting.

9. Equipment Repair and Maintenance Services

Another possible side job for firefighters is equipment-related work.

If you have strong mechanical or maintenance skills, you could offer services involving small engines, tools, outdoor equipment or general maintenance.

Potential customers might include homeowners, property managers or small businesses.

However, this option depends heavily on your existing technical ability.

You should also account for workspace requirements, parts, tools, insurance and local regulations.

For someone who already enjoys mechanical projects, this can be more attractive than taking a completely unrelated part-time job.

10. Online and Digital Side Hustles

Not every side hustle for firefighters needs to involve physical labor.

Firefighters can also explore online work that can be completed during suitable downtime away from their regular job.

Examples include:

- Writing
- Video editing
- Online tutoring
- Digital products
- Website management
- Content creation
- Freelance research
- Educational content

The advantage is flexibility. There is no need to drive to a customer's property, and some tasks can be completed in shorter blocks of free time.

However, online income usually takes time to build. A new website, social account or freelance profile may not produce meaningful income immediately.

For this reason, digital work is often better treated as a long-term business-building project rather than guaranteed quick money.

Side Hustle Comparison for Firefighters

Side Hustle	Main Advantage	Startup Requirements	Sche
Per-Diem EMS	Uses existing certification	Active credentials	Exce
Handyman Work	Flexible project scheduling	Tools, insurance, possible license	Exce

Side Hustle	Main Advantage	Startup Requirements	Sche
Fire Safety Consulting	Professional expertise	Credentials, insurance	Very
Home Inspection	Uses safety knowledge	Training, licensing, insurance	Very
CPR Training	Paid by class	Instructor qualification/equipment	Exce
Fire Investigation	Specialized expertise	Experience and credentials	Goo
Personal Training	Individual appointments	Certification and insurance	Very
Landscaping	Easy recurring model	Equipment and transportation	Exce
Equipment Repair	Uses technical skills	Tools and workspace	Goo
Online Work	Location flexibility	Computer and specific skills	Flex

There is no single option that works for every firefighter. The right choice depends on available time, existing skills, certification requirements, startup costs and how much physical work you want to perform outside your regular shifts.

How the 24-On, 48-Off Schedule Affects Side Hustles

A 24-on/48-off schedule can provide significant blocks of free time, but firefighters should not treat every hour away from the station as working time.

Recovery matters.

If your first day after a long shift is primarily used for sleep and recovery, you may realistically have fewer usable hours than your schedule appears to provide.

That makes project-based work particularly useful.

For example, a home inspection can be scheduled for a specific block. A landscaping route can be organized for one day. A CPR class can be booked in advance.

The source article similarly emphasizes that longer off-duty blocks make project-based work more practical than jobs requiring scattered evening availability.

What About a 24-On, 72-Off Schedule?

A 24-on/72-off schedule provides another full day away from the station compared with a 24-on/48-off rotation.

That additional time can make it easier to run a small service business.

For example, someone could potentially dedicate:

- Day 1 to recovery
- Day 2 to customer appointments
- Day 3 to larger projects
- Day 4 to administration or personal responsibilities

Of course, individual schedules and department requirements differ, so this should not be treated as a universal formula.

The important idea is to build your side income around your actual available energy, not simply the number of hours listed on the calendar.

Side Hustles Firefighters Should Approach Carefully

Not every money-making idea is suitable for someone working in public safety.

Large unlicensed projects

Never assume you can perform major contracting work without meeting licensing requirements.

Work without insurance

Consulting, inspections, repairs and other professional services can create financial liability if something goes wrong.

Low-paying gig platforms

A job that advertises a payment amount may look attractive until you subtract travel time, platform fees, equipment costs and taxes.

Conflicts with your department

Before starting any outside employment, review your department's rules.

Some departments may require disclosure or approval of secondary employment.

Sacrificing recovery

Extra income is not useful if the schedule leaves you too exhausted to perform your primary job safely.

How to Start a Firefighter Side Hustle

Starting does not require building a huge business immediately.

Use a simple process.

Step 1: Check your department policy

Find out whether outside employment requires disclosure, approval or specific restrictions.

Step 2: Choose a skill you already have

Existing experience can reduce both startup costs and learning time.

Step 3: Calculate the real hourly return

Do not only look at the advertised rate.

Subtract:

- Travel
- Equipment
- Insurance
- Platform fees
- Supplies
- Taxes
- Administrative time

Step 4: Start with a small workload

Try one or two clients or shifts first.

This helps you determine whether the side hustle fits your schedule.

Step 5: Build repeat customers

Recurring customers can make income more predictable than constantly searching for new jobs.

Step 6: Track income and expenses

Keep business records from the beginning. Depending on your circumstances and location, you may have tax obligations associated with self-employment income.

Can Firefighters Make Extra Money on Their Days Off?

Yes, there are several ways firefighters can potentially generate additional income during off-duty periods.

The strongest opportunities often have one thing in common: they work with the firefighter schedule instead of against it.

A per-diem EMS shift can use an existing certification. A home inspection can occupy a few concentrated hours. Landscaping can be organized into routes. Consulting can turn professional knowledge into a service. Fitness coaching can be divided into individual appointments.

The source material similarly emphasizes that firefighters can use their longer blocks of off-duty time for project-based and professional side work.

Final Thoughts

A successful side hustle for firefighters does not necessarily have to become a second full-time career.

For some firefighters, picking up an occasional EMS shift may be enough. Others may want to build a small inspection, handyman, landscaping, training or consulting business that generates recurring income.

The most important factors are flexibility, skill fit, startup costs, liability, licensing and recovery time.

Start with something you understand, test it with a manageable workload and increase your commitment only when the numbers and schedule make sense.

Your days off can create an opportunity to build firefighter side income, but the goal should be to create additional income without allowing the side business to interfere with your primary career or personal life.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is a good side hustle for firefighters?

Potential options include per-diem EMS work, handyman services, home inspection, fire-safety consulting, CPR instruction, personal training, landscaping and fire investigation consulting. The right option depends on your qualifications, schedule and local requirements.

What are the best side jobs for firefighters on days off?

Jobs that can be completed in full-day or appointment-based blocks tend to fit rotating firefighter schedules well. Examples include home inspections, contracting, landscaping, EMS shifts and safety instruction.

Can firefighters work a second job?

In many departments, outside employment is possible, but firefighters should check their department's specific policies before accepting paid work. Some employers require disclosure, approval or restrictions related to conflicts of interest.

How can firefighters make extra money without working every day?

A project-based or per-diem business can allow you to work only on selected days. Consulting, home inspection, landscaping, handyman work and per-diem EMS are examples of models that can potentially be scheduled around shifts.

Is home inspection a good side business for firefighters?

Home inspection may be a natural fit for firefighters who have experience with buildings, hazards and safety. However, licensing, training and insurance requirements vary by location and should be checked before starting.

Can firefighters make money from CPR training?

Yes. Qualified instructors can potentially earn money by providing CPR and first-aid classes to organizations and individuals. Instructor requirements depend on the training organization and local circumstances.

What should firefighters consider before starting a side hustle?

Consider your department's outside-employment rules, licensing requirements, insurance, taxes, startup costs, travel time and recovery schedule. A side hustle should not interfere with your primary responsibilities.

How much can a firefighter make from a side hustle?

There is no single amount. Income depends on the type of work, location, hours, experience, certifications, pricing and operating expenses. Employee wages and self-employed revenue should also be compared carefully because business revenue is not the same as take-home profit.

Can a firefighter start a business on their days off?

Yes, depending on department rules and local regulations. Service businesses such as landscaping, handyman work, inspection and consulting can potentially be structured around blocks of off-duty time.

What is the easiest side hustle for a firefighter to start?

For a firefighter who already has the necessary credentials, picking up per-diem EMS work may require less new training than starting an entirely new business. For someone without that certification, the easiest option may instead depend on existing skills and equipment.